CYBER SAFETY GUY

INSTAGRAM

THE BASICS PARENTS NEED TO KNOW

Instagram is a popular social media platform where kids share photos, videos, messages and stories, connect with friends and discover new content.

Here's what parents need to know.

1.2 BILLION+ monthly active Instagram users worldwide — Meta (2024)

71% of teens (13–17) use Instagram — Pew Research (2023)

53 MINUTES average time teens spend on Instagram daily — DataReportal (2024)

TOP 3 app teens say they use most often — Pew Research (2023)

WHAT KIDS DO ON INSTAGRAM

FEED
Scroll through photos, videos and Reels from friends, creators and accounts they follow.

STORIES
Share moments that disappear after 24 hours. Stories can include polls, questions and links.

REELS
Watch or create short, entertaining videos. Reels are highly addictive and easy to lose track of.

DMs (DIRECT MESSAGES)
Private messages with friends or strangers. Group chats can include people they don't know well.

EXPLORE
Discover new content, accounts and trends based on what they like and who they follow.

LIVE
Go live to broadcast in real time and interact with viewers.

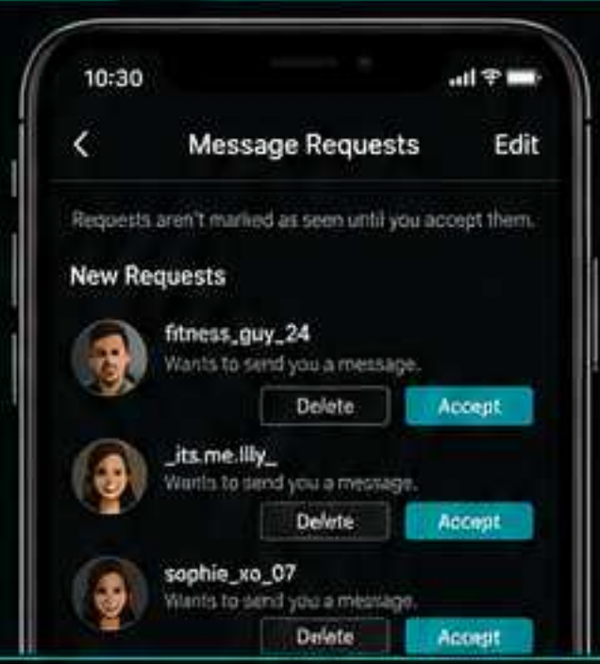
FOLLOWERS & LIKES
Build followers, get likes and comments. Validation can affect self-esteem and confidence.

WHY KIDS LOVE INSTAGRAM

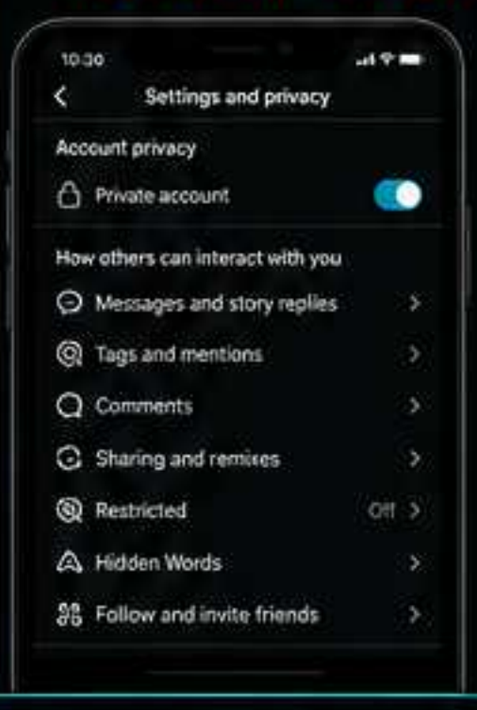
- It's visual, fun and creative.
- Helps them stay connected with friends.
- They can express themselves.
- Builds confidence and skills.
- Feels like belonging.

RISKS PARENTS SHOULD KNOW

- Strangers can follow, message and manipulate.
- Inappropriate content can appear in feed or Explore.
- Pressure to look perfect can hurt self-esteem.
- Cyberbullying can happen in comments or DMs.
- Oversharing can lead to privacy and safety risks.
- Scams, fake accounts and phishing links exist.



INSTAGRAM PRIVACY: WHAT PARENTS CAN CONTROL



Private account
Only approved followers can see posts and stories.

Who can message you
Choose "People you follow" or "Don't receive requests".

Comments
Control who can comment (Everyone / People you follow / No one).

Activity Status
Turn off "Activity Status" so others can't see when your child is online.

Limits
Limit unwanted interactions without blocking.

Hidden Words
Hide offensive words and phrases in comments and messages.

Sensitive Content Control
Reduce sensitive content in Explore and recommended content.

TIPS TO HELP YOUR CHILD STAY SAFE

- Talk about what they see, share and experience.
- Encourage them to think before they post.
- Remind them: not everything is real online.
- Set boundaries around screen time.
- Don't share personal info (school, location, phone number, etc.).
- Report and block anything that feels wrong.
- Encourage breaks and offline activities.
- Stay involved and keep the conversation open.

CONVERSATION STARTERS

- Who do you follow and why?
- What kind of content makes you feel good (or bad)?
- Has anyone ever said or done something that made you uncomfortable?

- Do you ever feel pressure to post or look a certain way?
- What would you do if a stranger messaged you something weird?

RED FLAGS TO WATCH FOR

- Sudden secrecy about Instagram use.
- Getting upset after being online.
- Spending much more time on Instagram.
- Unusual messages or new "online friends".
- Drop in mood or self-esteem.

QUICK DO'S & DON'TS

DO
- Encourage open conversations.
- Know their username and followers.
- Review privacy settings together.
- Praise good choices.
- Be a trusted place for help.

DON'T
- Spy or snoop.
- Overreact—listen first.
- Stereotype all online friends.
- Ignore problems.
- Blame or judge.

WHERE TO GET HELP

Childline
0800 1111
childline.org.uk

The Mix
0808 808 4994
themix.org.uk

Internet Matters
internetmatters.org
Advice, guides and tools for parents

REMEMBER

Your involvement today helps your child make safer choices tomorrow.

NEED TO TALK? CHILDLINE | **0800 1111** childline.org.uk | **YOU ARE NOT ALONE** We're here for you.